

HIGHS 'N LOWS (From top) IAS officers Sanjay Prasad, Awanish Awasthi and Navneet Sehgal

was apparently impressed with Prasad's efforts during the Covid-19 crisis in the state. The CM had brought him back from central deputation in 2019 after he served four years in the Centre as joint secretary in the defence production and science and technology departments.

Not everyone in Yogi's cabinet is happy about the shake-up. Says a minister, on condition of anonymity, "The transfers are being discussed in political circles too, for we all know how big a role bureaucrats play in this regime. Sehgal and Awasthi were very capable officers with contacts right from the local level to the national media. It'll not be easy for anyone to replace them." The chief minister's office (CMO) has now increased its control over various departments, he adds. "Maybe the CM wants to send out the message that his new team will run the show now."

The source in the CMO feels "too much self-branding" could have been a reason for some officers, including Sehgal, being offloaded. Sehgal's trouble-shooter credentials, though, had helped the government get out of many tight spots, including managing the media during the Hathras rape controversy. His flair for media management had been noticed even during the stints of the two previous CMs. But by now, Awasthi and he had come to be so identified with the present dispensation that they were on the list of officers the Samajwadi Party had sought the removal of for "the fair conduct" of assembly polls earlier this year. "Sehgal was brought in to give the government an image makeover. He's also due to retire in a year, so perhaps the CM wants to give a chance to younger people," says the source. That said, rumours abound of Awasthi's re-entry in some role even after his retirement. Alok Ranjan, retired bureaucrat and former UP chief secretary, says, "In the bureaucracy, division of work in a proper way is essential. Home and information are very important departments and need a dedicated person to handle them." And a degree of decentralisation of powers is necessary in every government set-up for policies to be effective on the ground, he adds.

In other key transfers, Partha Sarthi Sen Sharma was given charge of the medical, health and family welfare departments as principal secretary. The 1994 batch IAS officer was also a favourite of former chief minister Akhilesh Yadav, serving as his secretary in the CMO. Interestingly, 1997 batch officer Dr Hari Om, who was principal secretary, general administration, has been given social welfare. Hari Om was Gorakhpur DM during the SP regime when Yogi was arrested in 2007.

The reshuffle is also being seen in the context of complaints made by several ministers about bureaucrats being "uncooperative". Amit Mohan, recently ticked off by deputy CM Brajesh Pathak over 'controversial transfers' in the health department, has been reassigned to MSME, which some would call a promotion. Officials close to Sehgal claim he had a huge role in the department's makeover, and it turning into a key portfolio. MSMEs in UP contribute around 80 per cent of the state's exports. Sehgal also was central to the branding of the ODOP (one district one product) scheme. Products from the UP programme made headlines after Prime Minister Narendra Modi used them as diplomatic gifts at the recent G7 Summit in Germany. The PM gifted eight products marked under the ODOP programme. ■

THE TRANSFER OF 16 SENIOR IAS OFFICERS HAS SHAKEN UP THE BUREAUCRACY IN YOGI'S UTTAR PRADESH

By Moazum Mohammad in Srinagar

Political motives, overlapping and separating, always in a flux, hardly follow the narrow and straight. The latest development to rock Jammu and Kashmir politics—the exit of veteran leader and former J&K chief minister Ghulam Nabi Azad from the Congress on August 26—traces precisely such a surprising arc. As Azad announced the floating of his own national outfit, there began an exodus of former legislators and party workers from the Congress, leaving it denuded of leadership in Jammu and Kashmir. As many as 36 leaders have quit the party to join Azad. Starting his political journey from Jammu, where he addressed a rally on September 4, Azad received a rousing reception and announced his as-yet-unnamed party's main agenda: restoration of J&K's statehood and land rights to locals—both annulled along with Article 370 in 2019—as also employment for native domiciles.

In a now-famous five-page letter addressed to interim Congress president Sonia Gandhi, the 73-year-old leader detailed the reasons for his resignation: Rahul Gandhi's "immature" style of working, how "the entire consultative mechanism that existed was demolished by him", the sidelining of experienced leaders and "a new coterie of inexperienced sycophants" taking centre-stage. These ostensible reasons for his disaffection have become talking points for the Congress as it enters another round of gloomy introspection. However, insiders say the real trigger was the reconstitution of the J&K state unit and—ironically—the appointment of Vikar Rasool Wani, considered an Azad loyalist, as its president on August 16. Prima facie, Wani's appointment was meant to assuage the disgruntled 'G-23' leader with the elevation of an acolyte, but its real motive was to cut Azad down to size, say the insiders. Indeed, Azad had recommended four persons for the post, including Wani, but had put his weight behind G.M. Saroori and Peerzada Mohammad Sayed.

Wani has shared a cordial relationship with Rahul Gandhi since his days as